Ganesh' quite loudly. When I thought that we had just about had it, the rogue elephant turned around and retreated into the thicket. I looked back and saw people watching the drama. Somehow the jeep started and we quickly drove off, thanking our stars.

Our relationship with Brigadier (later Lieutenant General) Vadehra and Taran Vadehra, his very warm and affectionate wife, remains very close even today. He made me into a tougher soldier. After a year or so, there was a change of commanders, and Brigadier N.K. Talwar took over. His was a different leadership style – softer and yet fairly effective. I noticed that several people tried to cosy upto Brigadier Talwar and said a lot of things to please him. I didn't change my colours and my loyalty to the previous brigade commander, while being equally loyal to the successor. Brigadier Talwar, an exceptional professional, was mature enough to see through it all. He was very happy with my work and I continued to contribute towards the operational effectiveness of the formation, with his guidance. We also have a wonderful relationship with Nikki and Kusum Talwar, and we have kept in touch ever since. I learnt a lot from both of my brigade commanders.

On completion of my stipulated tenure of two years as a brigade major at New Mal, I was posted back in February 1977 to my battalion 9 Maratha LI, which was located at Jalandhar Cantonment. It was nice to be back home – back to regimental soldiering. I was appointed as 'A' Company Commander. In no other command assignment is an officer closer to his men than in this post. Our focus was on training, administration and sports. The aim of every company commander was to win the inter-company championship trophy. Every tournament we played was like a battle. Even the ladies and children joined in to cheer up the teams. Vivek and Sonia, my son and daughter, would always take on the mantle of the 'screaming brigade', and be the cheerleaders. The battlefield was the Katoch Stadium. Nearly twenty-eight years later, on the same sports field, I would address a 'Sainik Sammelan' of